

Three prompt patterns for everyday teaching tasks

When the answer disappoints, the next move is usually a better prompt. Pick the pattern that fits your task. Iterate in plain language until it's right.

PATTERN 1

The Brief

Default starter for any new task.

TEMPLATE

You are a *[role: e.g. high school biology teacher]*.

Context: You have *[class size and grade]* who just covered *[topic and what they already know]*.

Task: *[what you want, specifically]*.

Constraints: *[reading level, length, things to avoid]*.

Format: *[exact structure, e.g. 5 questions: 2 recall, 2 short-answer, 1 application; with answer key]*.

PATTERN 2

The Critic

When you've already drafted something.

TEMPLATE

I've drafted *[a quiz / rubric / parent email / lesson plan]* for *[audience]*. Please review it against these criteria:

[criterion 1, e.g. clarity for ESL students]
[criterion 2, e.g. tests analysis, not just recall]
[criterion 3, e.g. fits a 20-minute slot]

Suggest specific edits. Don't rewrite from scratch.

Here it is:

[paste your draft]

PATTERN 3

The Differentiator

When one version isn't enough.

TEMPLATE

Take the *[worksheet / passage / question set]* above and produce a version for:

[a student reading two grade levels below]

Keep the same content and learning goal. Adjust:

Vocabulary and sentence length
 Number and difficulty of questions
 Length of any reading passage

Flag anything you simplified so I can double-check it.

WORKED EXAMPLE

The Brief, filled in

A real prompt for a grade 9 reading comprehension exercise on photosynthesis. It uses five of the six components; the sixth, examples, would slot in if you had a sample question style to paste.

Role. You are a high school biology teacher.

Context. You have 25 grade 9 students who just finished a unit on photosynthesis. They know the basic equation, the role of chlorophyll, and the difference between light and dark reactions.

Task. Write a reading comprehension exercise for a 20-minute classroom activity.

Constraints. Keep vocabulary at a 9th grade reading level. No equations beyond the basic photosynthesis equation.

Format. A 200 to 250 word passage, then 5 questions: 2 recall, 2 short-answer comprehension, 1 application. Answer key with brief explanations.

The six components, as a checklist

1 Role

Who the tool should be.

2 Context

What it needs to know about your situation.

3 Task

What you actually want it to do.

4 Constraints

Limits, audience, things to avoid.

5 Format

How the answer should be structured.

6 Examples

A sample of what good looks like.

Iterate in plain language

- "Make it shorter."
- "Use simpler vocabulary."
- "Add three harder questions."
- "Try again, but for ESL students."
- "Give me three different versions."

Most good outputs are the third or fourth message in a conversation, not the first.